

WHAT IS MUSIC?

What sounds like music to your ears could make someone else tune out. As music is not a physical entity, defining it is difficult, especially with all of the genres that have emerged over the past century. If music is simply “organized sound,” it could encompass factory noise and washing machines, while the presence of rhythm or harmony can be a question of personal taste. So, while anything may be classed as music, when it’s your music, you call the tune.

BACKSTAGE PASS

SOUNDING BOARD

Some artists try to blur the boundaries between art and music, and this is known as sound art. American John Cage (1912–1992) is known for his 1952 composition “4’33” in which a performer sits onstage for four minutes, 33 seconds. Not a single note is played because Cage wanted the audience to hear the sounds of the environment instead of the performer. He believed that any sounds could be considered music. Does that sound silly to you?

**“MUSIC AND RHYTHM
FIND THEIR WAY INTO
THE SECRET PLACES
OF THE SOUL.”**

Plato (c. 427–347 BCE),
Greek philosopher

WHITE NOISE

Another description sometimes given to music is “organized tones.” This cannot be the case with rock music, one of the most popular genres in the world. Rock sometimes uses white noise, which has no tone. White noise is sound with continuous frequencies of equal intensity. When advertisements sound louder on television, they are actually not. It is white noise and interference layered in order to attract the audience’s attention. White noise makes the brain work harder to understand it, so the viewer unwittingly takes more notice of the advertisements than they otherwise would.

